CTIN 290: Digital Media Workshop

Units: 2

Time:

Once weekly, 2 hours 50 minutes.

Location and Modality:

In Person

Course Description

We will study and practice how narrative video games express meaning, make topics and themes playable, and invoke the player's emotions.

Artists want to communicate in order to *question* and *persuade*. What does this mean for narrative game design? To frame it personally, *is life a story or a game?*

This course has four overarching topics.

- Visual Grammar
- Storytelling: The Player Character's Role and Situation
- Worldbuilding: Playable Worlds Expressive Through the Space's Edges
- Pragmatic Practices for Creators

The first two topics focus on two principles at a narrative designer's disposal: the language of the moving image and the video game player's role. The third considers the game world itself: how its limits, rules, and responses can express meaning through play.

The fourth topic — pragmatic creative practices — explores how successful artists imagine compelling ideas, execute on a small scale, and participate in a culture of critique and creative growth.

Grammar

We study the visual grammar of cinema and how it provides a valuable starting point for how video games tell stories. We consider how color, lighting, composition, montage, and cinematography shape our attention in order to communicate.

Cinema language is also sonic. Audio design is one of the most powerful and flexible of the narrative game designer's tools, and film audio shows us much of what is possible in video games.

Playable Roles

Mainstream storytelling features a character who attempts to *control* their reality. They want something, and we anticipate how they might get it. What comes next: surprises, some small and some large.

We continue with alternatives to the mainstream, such as stories that close not with the protagonist attaining power but with the character (and player) *discovering* insight and understanding.

Narrative games complicate the protagonist paradigm because there are two main characters: the protagonist and the player. We study how narrative game *situations* inform what the player can and does do.

The course is organized around three player roles, one per project:

- **The Investigator** (World as Evidence) — asks *What happened?* The player reconstructs past events by reading the world: seeing, listening, finding, and collecting, rather than being told.
- **The Traveler** (World as Presence) — asks *What is this experience?* The player finds a path and bears witness to events as they unfold, and leaves with a personal interpretation.
- **The Dreamer** (World as Enigma) — asks *What does this world express?* The player solves surreal, metaphorical spaces as puzzles, moving from the incomprehensible to the understood.

Worldbuilding

Situations also provide our way into worldbuilding. As the player moves from one situation to the next, they meet the world, learn its rules, experience its responses, and discover what lies at or beyond its edges.

Rather than developing the world backstory or lore, we focus on making small playable worlds feel imminently coherent, inhabited, and expressive through what they provide as well as constrain.

Creative Practices

Throughout the semester we learn pragmatic creative practices. How do successful artists imagine and articulate their early ideas? What techniques help a student take on a compelling project that can reasonably be finished?

The outcome of this course is to prepare students for later classes in which they will be expected to imagine compelling game ideas and then make them.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

Visual and Interactive Storytelling

1. Describe how visual storytelling builds subtext and theme, with an emphasis on point of view.

2. Apply color theory, composition, lighting, and camera operation to compose communicative visual designs.
3. Create story stakes, pressure, and growth for players (and player characters).
4. Compare how cinematic and interactive storytelling express change and contrast — and therefore surprise.
5. Analyze the arc of experience in films and games.
6. Discuss how research into prior work informs their own work.

Digital Media Development

7. Build small interactive worlds in the Unity game engine.
8. Translate photography and video camera operation into game camera design.
9. Identify the essential components of 3D models — materials, textures, and meshes — and incorporate them into a game.
10. Create meaningful sound designs.

Production Methods

11. Explain how self-direction couples with a shared creative vision.
12. Give and receive critique.
13. Use ideation, brainstorming, and prototyping approaches.

Prerequisite(s): None
Concurrent Enrollment: None
Recommended Preparation: None

Technological Proficiency and Hardware/Software Required

Students need a laptop capable of running the Unity game engine.

Readings and Supplementary Materials

Readings are provided by the instructor in the class folder.

- *The Science of Storytelling* (selected sections) — Will Storr
- *Painting with Light* (selections) — John Alton
- *Game Design as Narrative Architecture* — Henry Jenkins
- *Down the Rabbit Hole* — Matt Margini
- Short readings on each of the three player roles, provided by the instructor

Assessments and Assignments

Requirements for research papers and assignments

Three projects, each built in Unity, spread across the full semester. Each project is preceded by smaller milestones that are playtested in class.

Project 1 — The Investigator (Weeks 1–5). A small narrative space built with environmental storytelling. The player constructs the story by investigating the world as evidence — reading, listening, seeing, finding, or collecting.
Learning objectives: 1, 2, 5, 7, 9, 10. *Graded on:* how clearly the player's role and intended experience come through during play.

Project 2 — The Traveler (Weeks 6–10). A level built around a maze with multiple paths, through which the player moves in three stages: feeling lost (with wonder), recognizing a pattern that may help them (with excitement), and finding their way. By the end the player holds a personal interpretation of what the experience was about — one theme, dilemma, conviction, question, or insight. Lighting, sound, and camera must all be used to set the mood.
Learning objectives: 2, 3, 4, 5, 7, 8, 10. *Graded on:* how clearly the player's role and intended experience come through during play.

Project 3 — The Dreamer (Weeks 11–15). A short series of surreal rooms that the player must solve as puzzles to move from one to the next. Images and mechanics are at first inexplicable and read as metaphor. Modeled on Alice in *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*, the player passes through three stages: Legibility (what are these objects, what do they do?), Opportunity (what solutions can I imagine?), and Performance (can I carry one out?).
Learning objectives: 1, 3, 4, 7, 9, 11, 13. *Graded on:* how clearly the player's role and intended experience come through during play.

Milestones. Each project has milestones — for example a written premise, a core-mechanic build, and a playable draft — due at class time and playtested in class.
Learning objectives: 12, 13. *Graded on:* completion and effort.

Exercises. Short warm-up assignments, such as a walkable gallery of a chosen artist's work built from primitives in Unity, and a group play session of *The Exit 8* with written observations.
Learning objectives: 5, 6, 7. *Graded on:* completion and effort.

Final Reflection. One page on what the student learned this semester and the classes and projects they plan to take on over the next two years, due at the scheduled final exam time.
Learning objectives: 6, 11.

Participation

Participation is 15% of the course grade and is assessed on what students contribute. Students earn participation credit by:

- coming to class prepared, having completed the assigned readings and play;

- bringing a playable build to each scheduled in-class playtest;
- playing classmates' builds and giving thoughtful, specific feedback during critique;
- taking part in workshops and discussions.

Grading Breakdown and Scale

Assignment	% of Grade
Project 1 — The Investigator	15%
Project 2 — The Traveler	15%
Project 3 — The Dreamer	20%
Milestones (8 total)	25%
Exercises (2)	5%
Participation, playtesting, and critique	15%
Final reflection	5%
Total	**100%**

Final course grades: A, 93–100; A–, 90–92; B+, 87–89; B, 83–86; B–, 80–82; C+, 77–79; C, 73–76; C–, 70–72; D+, 67–69; D, 63–66; D–, 60–62; F, below 60.

Course Policies

Attendance

Attendance is expected at every class meeting; playtests and critiques depend on everyone being present. Students receive one forgiven absence over the semester. Each additional absence lowers the participation grade by 5 points. Four late arrivals count as one absence. Students should notify the instructor of an absence by email, before class when possible. University-approved absences, including religious observances and student-athlete travel, are accommodated; students should notify the instructor in advance to arrange how to make up missed work.

Late Work

Assignments are due at the scheduled class time unless stated otherwise.

- A project submitted within 24 hours after the due time loses 10% of its grade; within one week, 25%. After one week it is not accepted.
- Late milestones and exercises receive half credit if submitted before the next class meeting, and no credit after that.

Academic Integrity

The University of Southern California is foremost a learning community committed to fostering successful scholars and researchers dedicated to the pursuit of knowledge and the transmission of ideas. Academic misconduct is contrary to this fundamental mission and includes any act of dishonesty in the submission of academic work (either in draft or final form), as well as cheating, plagiarism, fabrication (e.g., falsifying data), knowingly assisting others in acts of academic dishonesty, and any act that gains or is intended to gain an unfair academic advantage. Students are expected to uphold the highest standards of academic integrity in all coursework. This course follows the expectations for academic integrity as stated in the USC Student Handbook. All students are expected to submit assignments that are original work and prepared specifically for the course/section in this academic term. Students may not submit work written by others or "recycle" work prepared for other courses without obtaining written permission from the instructor(s). Students suspected of academic misconduct will be reported to the Office of Academic Integrity.

Academic dishonesty has a far-reaching impact and is considered a serious offense against the university. Violations will result in a grade penalty, such as a failing grade on the assignment or in the course, and disciplinary action from the university, such as suspension or expulsion. For more information about academic integrity see the Student Handbook, the Office of Academic Integrity's website, and university policies on Research and Scholarship Misconduct. Please ask your instructor if you are unsure what constitutes unauthorized assistance on an exam or assignment or what information requires citation and/or attribution.

Instructors determine whether and how generative AI tools (such as ChatGPT, Copilot, Claude, Gemini, and similar applications) and other external resources (such as English-language translation tools) may be used in this course. Expectations may vary from assignment to assignment. This includes AI tools that record, transcribe, or summarize class sessions, which may require express instructor permission. Review the AI use guidance provided below carefully, and direct any questions to your instructor before submitting work.

Students seeking general guidance may consult the following resources:

- USC Student Handbook
- Generative AI General Policy
- Practical Tips for Using AI in Academic Work
- Office of Academic Integrity

Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) Tools

Free use.

Student Handbook Policies

Students are expected to know and follow the policies in the current USC Student Handbook. Policies especially relevant to this course include:

- **Classroom conduct.** Playtests and critiques ask students to share unfinished work. Feedback should address the work and be specific and constructive.
- **Distribution of course materials.** Readings, lecture materials, and project templates are provided for students enrolled in the course and may not be shared or posted outside it.
- **Intellectual property.** Students own the projects they create. Students are responsible for the rights to any third-party assets they use (art, sound, music, models) and must credit those sources in their projects.

Learning Experience Evaluations

Learning experience evaluations are the university's end-of-semester survey of each course. Students' responses shape how this course is taught in future semesters, and all students are encouraged to complete them. Because this is a workshop built on playtesting and critique, the instructor also asks for informal feedback at mid-semester and adjusts the remaining weeks in response where possible.

Course Schedule

The course schedule is subject to change; revisions will be announced in class.

Part 1 — The Investigator

Week 1 — Course introduction: why storytelling; the class as a culture; what is creativity; the three player roles and the three projects; grading. Film grammar: attention, film space, and eye line.
Due next week: install Unity (via Unity Hub); complete the student details form; read the Investigator reading. Project 1 assigned.

Week 2 — The value of uncertainty: how players predict and why surprise matters. Plot versus story, premise versus story, through *Tacoma* (2017) and *Blade Runner* (1982).
Due: Exercise — Walkable Artist Gallery.
Assigned: group play session of *The Exit 8*; read *Game Design as Narrative Architecture*.

Week 3 — *The Science of Storytelling*; cause and effect; cycles of partial information. Discussion of *The Exit 8*.
Due: The Exit 8 session notes; read *The Science of Storytelling* selections; Project 1 Milestone 1 — written premise (4–6 sentences emphasizing anticipation, intrigue, and curiosity).

Week 4 — Playtest.
Due: Project 1 Milestone 2 — one or two core story mechanics, with mood established through

sound.

Week 5 — Playtest and critique.
Due: **Project 1 — The Investigator.**

Part 2 — The Traveler

Week 6 — Lighting workshop on a sound stage (closed-toed shoes and heat-resistant gloves or a towel required). Introduction to the Traveler.
Due: read *Painting with Light* selections and the Traveler reading. Project 2 assigned.

Week 7 — Modernism and the avant-garde: interpretation over solution. Labyrinths and mazes.
Due: Project 2 Milestone 1 — written premise and maze sketch.

Week 8 — Finite worlds: worlds expressive through their edges. Playtest.
Due: Project 2 Milestone 2 — core mechanics and one loop of expectation to surprise.

Week 9 — Playtest.
Due: Project 2 Milestone 3 — two or three loops of expectation to surprise; lighting pass.

Week 10 — Playtest and critique.
Due: **Project 2 — The Traveler.**

Part 3 — The Dreamer

Week 11 — Creativity as a way of behaving. The Dreamer and *Alice in Wonderland*: metaphor, puzzles, and surrealism.
Due: read *Down the Rabbit Hole* and the Dreamer reading. Project 3 assigned.

Week 12 — Building imaginary worlds: invention, completeness, and consistency.
Due: Project 3 Milestone 1 — premise and one puzzle on paper.

Week 13 — Playtest.
Due: Project 3 Milestone 2 — core puzzle loop working and metaphor started.

Week 14 — Postmodernism.
Due: Project 3 Milestone 3 — alpha: the player's path is in place, even with bugs and missing art or sound.

Week 15 — Playtest, presentations, and reflection: what do you know now that you did not know then?
Due: **Project 3 — The Dreamer.**

Final — Reflection: one page on what you learned this semester and the classes and projects you plan to take on over the next two years, due at the scheduled final exam time.

Statement on University Academic and Support Systems

Students and Disability Accommodations

USC welcomes students with disabilities into all of the University's educational programs. The Office of Student Accessibility Services (OSAS) is responsible for the determination of appropriate accommodations for students who encounter disability-related barriers. Once a student has completed the OSAS process (registration, initial appointment, and submitted documentation) and accommodations are determined to be reasonable and appropriate, a Letter of Accommodation (LOA) will be available to generate for each course. The LOA must be given to each course instructor by the student and followed up with a discussion. This should be done as early in the semester as possible as accommodations are not retroactive. More information can be found at osas.usc.edu. You may contact OSAS at (213) 740-0776 or via email at osasfrontdesk@usc.edu.

Student Financial Aid and Satisfactory Academic Progress

To be eligible for certain kinds of financial aid, students are required to maintain Satisfactory Academic Progress (SAP) toward their degree objectives. Visit the Financial Aid Office webpage for undergraduate- and graduate-level SAP eligibility requirements and the appeals process.

Support Systems

Counseling and Mental Health

Contact: (213) 740-9355, 24/7 on call
Free and confidential mental health treatment for students, including short-term psychotherapy, group counseling, stress fitness workshops, and crisis intervention.

988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline

Contact: 988 for both calls and text messages, 24/7 on call
The 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline (formerly known as the National Suicide Prevention Lifeline) provides free and confidential emotional support to people in suicidal crisis or emotional distress 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, across the United States. The Lifeline consists of a national network of over 200 local crisis centers, combining custom local care and resources with national standards and best practices. The new, shorter phone number makes it easier for people to remember and access mental health crisis services (though the previous 1 (800) 273-8255 number will continue to function indefinitely) and represents a continued commitment to those in crisis.

CARE-SC: Confidential Advocacy, Resources, and Education Support Center

Contact: (213) 740-9355 (WELL), 24/7/365 on call
Confidential advocates, prevention educators, and professional counseling teams work to promote a universal culture of consent, and prevent and respond to gender- and power-based harm. Services available to all USC students at no cost.

Office of Civil Rights Compliance

Contact: (213) 740-5086

Information about how to get help or help someone affected by harassment, discrimination, retaliation on the basis of a protected characteristic, rights of protected classes, reporting options, and additional resources for students, faculty, staff, visitors, and applicants.

USC Campus Support and Intervention
Contact: (213) 740-0411, uscsupport@usc.edu
Assists students and families in resolving complex personal, financial, and academic issues adversely affecting their success as a student.

USC Emergency Information
Latest updates regarding safety, including ways in which instruction will be continued if an officially declared emergency makes travel to campus infeasible.

USC Department of Public Safety
For 24 hour emergency assistance or to report a crime: UPC: (213) 740-4321, HSC: (323) 442-1000.
For 24 hour non-emergency assistance or information: UPC: (213) 740-6000, HSC: (323) 442-1200.

Office of the Ombuds
Contact: (213) 821-9556 (UPC) / (323) 442-0382 (HSC)
A safe and confidential place to share your USC-related issues with a University Ombuds who will work with you to explore options or paths to manage your concern.

Occupational Therapy Faculty Practice
Contact: (323) 442-2850 or otfp@med.usc.edu
Lifestyle Redesign services for USC students to support health promoting habits and routines that enhance quality of life and academic performance.

The Office of Sustainability
The Office of Sustainability promotes numerous ways for all Trojans to study, work, and live sustainably at USC. Students can access tools, resources, and opportunities on their website and in the Sustainability Hub in the Student Union Building, Suite 101.

USC Report & Response
USC Report and Response provides a front door to reporting concerns, including an ability to report anonymously, which violate university policies or go against our Unifying Values and helps connect you with the support you need. The website provides a list of confidential resources, supporting offices, and policies that are available to our university community. The Resources page includes information regarding the university's response in the event of immigration enforcement activity on campus or involving a student or employee. Additional questions may be directed to the Office of Professionalism and Ethics (OPE) at ope@usc.edu or by reviewing the Office of Professionalism and Ethics website.